

The Cold War

From the late 1940s, the United States set out to block the spread of communism worldwide. In this Cold War context, the struggle between the French and the Viet Minh was transformed from a local colonial conflict into part of a global confrontation.

◀◀ BEFORE

The Russian Revolution of 1917 created the Soviet Union, a communist state committed to fomenting world revolution.

RISE OF THE SUPERPOWERS

In World War II, the Soviet Union fought as an ally of the United States and Britain against Nazi Germany. After the war, **relations between the Soviet government** and its **former allies** deteriorated rapidly. Lines to mark **zones of occupation** by Soviet and Western forces became fortified borders between **communist and anti-communist blocs**.

Addressing Congress in March 1947, US President Harry Truman announced the decision to support “free peoples” anywhere in the world menaced with “subjugation by armed minorities or by outside pressures.” The aim was to prevent the spread of communism and Soviet influence, which were seen as a direct threat to American national security. The “Truman Doctrine” was followed by a series of events—including the communist seizure of power in Czechoslovakia and the Soviet blockade of Berlin in 1948–49—that brought the United States into the openly hostile confrontation with the Soviet Union known as the Cold War. The explosion of the first Soviet atom bomb, in a remote area of Kazakhstan in August 1949, made this a confrontation between nuclear-armed powers.

“Every year **humanity** takes a **step toward communism.**”

SOVIET LEADER NIKITA KHRUSHCHEV TO SIR WILLIAM HAYTER, JUNE 1956

The Korean War

While American fears about communism were turning into full-blown paranoia, Mao Zedong led the communists to victory in the Chinese Civil War. This dramatic development shifted the focus of American attention from Europe to Asia. At the end of World War II, China’s neighbor Korea had been divided into Soviet and American zones of occupation. The Soviet zone had become communist North Korea, while a pro-American dictator ruled South Korea. When North Korean forces invaded the South in June 1950, the United States led a large-scale military intervention under the banner of the United Nations, repulsing the North Korean invaders.

The Korean War was to have an enduring effect on America’s approach to the later Vietnam War. In Korea, after the defeat of the North Korean invasion, American General Douglas MacArthur ordered his troops to advance into North Korea. China responded by sending its army into Korea, massively escalating the conflict and driving the UN forces back again.